A Purpose and Scope of the Triage Guide

This guide sets how incoming service tickets are classified, prioritised and passed between shifts so that nothing is dropped at handover. It applies to every queue in the service desk and to all staff who triage, own or receive tickets. The aim is consistent decisions: the same ticket should reach the same severity and owner regardless of who is on duty. Where local practice differs, the stricter rule applies until the guide is formally revised.

A.1 Intake Channels and Ticket Registration

Tickets arrive by portal form, email, phone and walk-in. Each channel is registered in the same system within the same working day, and the registrar records the requester, the affected service, the observed symptom and any deadline already promised. Email and phone reports must be transcribed into the ticket body rather than left in a mailbox. Duplicate reports of one incident are linked to a parent ticket so counts stay honest.

Supporting records are presented in Table 1.

A.1.1 Initial Classification and Severity Rules

Channel	Registrar	Deadline	Evidence
Portal	Requester	Same day	Form fields
Email	Desk staff	Same day	Mail excerpt
Phone	Desk staff	Same day	Call note
Walk-in	Desk staff	Same day	Intake note

Table 1: Comparison of intake channels and their registration duties

Classification starts with the affected service and the reported impact, not with the loudest requester. Triage assigns a category, a severity and an initial owner, then checks whether an open incident already covers the symptom. Severity reflects breadth and business effect: a single user blocked differs from a whole site unable to work. When evidence is thin, triage records what is unknown and sets a short review point instead of guessing.

A.1.1.1 Severity Assignment and Escalation Triggers

Severity levels run from routine to critical, and each level carries a response expectation and an escalation trigger. Triggers include multiple reports of one symptom, a service with no workaround, or a requester deadline that cannot be met within the normal queue. Escalation moves the ticket to a named senior owner and notifies the duty lead. Downgrades require a written reason, because quiet

reclassification hides demand and distorts later reporting.

A.1.1.1.1 Ownership, Queue Assignment and Response Clock

Every ticket has one accountable owner at any moment, even when several teams contribute. Assignment follows the service catalogue: the queue that owns the failing component takes the ticket, and assisting teams are recorded as contributors. The response clock starts at registration and pauses only for documented requester input. Owners must acknowledge within the published expectation and record the first diagnostic step taken, so the next person inherits evidence rather than a blank page.

Supporting records are presented in Table 2.

Level	Response	Trigger	Owner
Critical	Immediate	Site down	Duty lead
High	Same shift	No workaround	Team lead
Routine	Queued	Single user	Queue owner
Parked	Follow-up	Awaiting input	Queue owner

Table 2: Severity levels with response expectations and escalation triggers

A.1.1.1.1.1 First Response and Diagnostic Checklist

The first response confirms the symptom, checks the service status page, and runs the standard diagnostic checklist for the category. The owner records what was tested, what was observed, and what was ruled out. If the checklist resolves the issue, the ticket closes with the resolution note; if not, the owner states the next hypothesis and the evidence needed. Speculation is welcome only when labelled as such.

A.1.1.1.1.2 Requester Communication and Expectation Setting

Requesters receive a plain-language acknowledgement that names the owner, restates the symptom as understood, and gives the next update point. Updates are sent at each state change and before any promised deadline passes, even when the news is that work continues. Staff avoid promising fix times they do not control; they promise update times instead. Sensitive tickets use approved wording and never expose internal hostnames or colleague names.

A.1.1.1.2 Reassignment and Cross Team Handoff

Reassignment is a transfer of accountability, not a forward of the ticket. The outgoing owner writes a handoff note covering symptom, evidence gathered, hypotheses tested, current workaround and the exact next action. The incoming owner accepts explicitly before the clock resumes. If the receiving queue disputes ownership, the duty lead decides within the same shift and records the decision, so the ticket never bounces silently between teams.

Supporting records are presented in Table 3.

Duty	Outgoing	Incoming	Duty lead
Write note	Yes	No	Review
Accept owner	No	Yes	Arbitrate
Brief critical	Yes	Confirm	Observe
Resolve dispute	No	No	Decide

Table 3: Responsibilities split between outgoing and incoming owners at transfer

A.1.1.2 Documentation Standards for Triage Notes

Notes must let a stranger continue the work without asking questions. Each entry states the time, the actor, the action taken and the result observed. Free-text opinions are separated from recorded evidence, and links to logs or screenshots are preferred over pasted excerpts. Notes avoid abbreviations that only one team understands. At closure the resolution note explains the cause as far as it is known and flags anything still unproven.

A.1.2 Quality Review of Classification Decisions

A sample of closed tickets is reviewed each period against the severity rules and documentation standards. Reviewers check whether severity matched impact, whether ownership was clear at every stage, and whether handoff notes were sufficient. Findings feed a short coaching note to the relevant team rather than a blame list. Recurring misclassification points to a rule that needs clarifying, and the guide is amended accordingly.

A.2 Triage Metrics and Reporting Discipline

Reporting covers volume by category, response against expectation, reassignment counts and reopened tickets. Metrics describe the queue, not individual worth, and are read alongside the review findings. A rising reassignment rate usually signals unclear ownership boundaries rather than poor staff. Reports are shared with team leads monthly, and any metric used in planning must be defined in the same document so nobody argues about definitions after the fact.

B Shift Handover Procedure

Handover happens at fixed times and follows a fixed shape: open critical tickets first, then tickets awaiting requester input, then work in progress. The outgoing shift reads each note aloud and the incoming shift confirms understanding. Anything ambiguous is resolved before the outgoing shift leaves. The handover record lists the tickets discussed, the agreed next actions and who holds each one, and is stored with the shift log.

B.1 Handover Note Contents and Format

Each handover entry names the ticket, its severity, its owner, the last confirmed observation and the next action with a time. It states what the requester was last told, so the next shift does not contradict a promise. Open questions and suspected

causes are listed separately from confirmed facts. Entries are short enough to read under pressure but complete enough that no one needs to reopen the whole ticket history.

Supporting records are presented in Figure 1.

B.1.1 Critical Ticket Continuity Across Shifts

Critical tickets never wait for a convenient handover. The outgoing owner briefs the incoming owner directly, confirms access to the working channels, and stays reachable for a short overlap. The incoming owner restates the current hypothesis and the next diagnostic step before taking over. If no incoming owner is available, the duty lead is named as interim owner and that decision is recorded with a time.

B.1.1.1 Escalation Paths During Handover

During handover the escalation path must be known without consulting a directory. The handover record names the duty lead, the on-call engineer for each affected service and the communications contact for requester updates. If an escalation trigger fires mid-handover, the incoming shift owns it from the moment of acceptance, and the outgoing shift supports until the duty lead confirms the transfer is complete.

B.1.1.1.1 Open Work Tracking and Carryover Rules

Work that cannot finish within a shift is carried over deliberately, not by default. Carryover requires a live owner, a stated next action and a reason the work paused. Tickets awaiting requester input are parked with a follow-up date rather than carried as active work. The handover record distinguishes active carryover from parked items, so the incoming shift knows what genuinely needs attention first.

B.1.1.1.1.1 Handover Checklist and Sign-Off

The checklist is short and mandatory: every critical ticket briefed, every carryover item owned, every promise to a requester visible, and every escalation contact confirmed. Both shifts sign the handover record, and the signature means the incoming shift accepts the listed items, not that the outgoing shift is absolved of errors found later. Unsigned handovers are treated as incomplete and raised with the duty lead.

Supporting records are presented in Table 4.

B.1.1.1.1.2 Missed Handover and Recovery Steps

Item	By	When	Record
Critical briefed	Both	Handover	Shift log
Carryover owned	Incoming	Handover	Ticket note
Promises visible	Outgoing	Before exit	Handover
Contacts checked	Duty lead	Each shift	Contact list
Sign-off	Both	At end	Handover

Table 4: Checklist items confirmed before an incoming shift accepts a handover

When a handover is missed, the incoming shift reconstructs state from the ticket notes and the shift log before touching any

ticket. The duty lead is informed immediately, and any requester promise that has already lapsed is addressed first. The recovery record notes the gap, what was reconstructed and what remains uncertain. A repeated missed handover triggers a review of shift scheduling rather than a reminder to try harder.

B.1.1.1.2 Training New Staff on Handover Practice

New staff shadow two handovers before leading one, and their first led handover is observed by a senior colleague. Training covers note writing, the checklist, escalation contacts and the difference between active carryover and parked work. Trainees practise reconstructing a ticket from notes alone, which exposes gaps quickly. Competence is confirmed by the observer, not by attendance at a briefing session.

B.1.1.2 Audit Trail and Record Retention

Handover records, triage notes and closure summaries form the audit trail and are retained under the records schedule. Records must show who decided what and when, without exposing unnecessary personal data. Corrections are appended, never overwritten, and the reason for each correction is stated. Audit requests are answered from these records, so completeness at the time of writing matters more than tidiness later.

Supporting records are presented in Table 5.

Record	Held by	Purpose	Correction
Triage notes	Service desk	Show decisions	Append only
Handover	Shift lead	Show transfers	Append only
Closure note	Queue owner	Show outcome	Append only
Review findings	Desk manager	Show progress	Append only

Table 5: Records retained for audit and the reason each is kept

B.1.2 Continuous Improvement of Triage Practice

Improvements come from review findings, recurring ticket patterns and staff suggestions gathered at handover. Each proposed change names the problem it solves and the evidence behind it, and is trialled for a defined period before adoption. The guide is versioned, and every change is announced with the date it takes effect. Practices that no longer earn their effort are retired openly rather than left to linger.

B.2 Governance, Roles and Review Cycle

The service desk manager owns this guide, team leads maintain the category and severity rules, and the duty lead arbitrates ownership disputes. The guide is reviewed on a fixed cycle and after any critical incident that exposed a gap. Proposed amendments are circulated to all queues for comment before approval. Approved changes are communicated, trained where needed, and recorded in the version history with the effective date.



Figure 1: Fields that every handover entry must contain